

Coughs and sneezes

Your lungs and airways are always at work, taking in fresh air and pushing out stale air, and most of the time you don't notice them doing it. Occasionally, however, they might surprise you with an unexpected cough, sneeze, yawn, or hiccup. These processes mostly play a vital role in keeping you healthy, but some are a bit of a mystery.

SNEEZING

If something itchy gets in your nose, your body clears it out with a deafening blast of air: a sneeze.

After a sharp intake of breath, your eyes close and your rib muscles tighten to squeeze your lungs and blast air out, often with a brief scream. Your tongue rises to direct air into your nose, but most of the blast often comes out of the mouth.

WOW!

You can't cough, sneeze, yawn, hiccup, or laugh when you're dreaming, since most of your muscles are paralyzed during dreams.

Sneezes clear germs out of your nose but spread them to other people.

